

U1L17SP — Short Paper 4

Who Reasons More Dishonestly with Himself?

Week 17: Literary Self-Deception

Name: _____

Date: _____

The question

Who reasons more dishonestly with himself: Macbeth or Brutus? Compare the private reasoning each man uses before choosing political murder, then defend a fair judgment about the kind and degree of self-deception involved. You may choose either character, judge them equally self-deceiving in different ways, or argue that the charge fits one of them only partly. Your conclusion must be proportional to the evidence and fair to both characters. Here, reasoning dishonestly with oneself need not mean consciously telling a lie. It may include letting desire choose the conclusion, hiding a motive behind a cleaner reason, treating an assumption as proof, or declaring an action necessary before necessity has been established.

Text support

The accompanying *U1L17SP Text Supplement* prints Macbeth's private reasoning in *Macbeth* 1.7 and Brutus's oration reasoning in *Julius Caesar* 2.1. These are anchors, not limits. You may use any accurate line, action, choice, or consequence from either play; remembered events may be paraphrased accurately.

The assignment

Write a **two- to three-page handwritten comparison** on separate lined paper. Give it the title *Who Reasons More Dishonestly with Himself?* Organize the argument independently. It must:

- make a comparative claim that defines what *reasoning dishonestly with oneself* means in your argument;
- reconstruct each character's desire, conclusion, stated reasons, and at least one hidden assumption;
- apply the logic tools that best expose each case rather than forcing the same diagnosis on both;
- use at least four brief pieces of evidence, including exact quotations from both supplied passages;
- give each character fair counterpressure before reaching a qualified comparative judgment.

Plot summary is not analysis. Use an event only when you explain how it exposes, supports, or complicates a character's private reasoning.

The closed-world rule

You may use only the supplied text supplement, the assigned plays or course-provided primary texts, course handouts, and notes you made during class.

Do not use AI, the internet, online summaries, outside criticism, a tutor, a parent, a friend, or anyone else's planning, revising, correcting, sentences, or ideas.

At the end of your paper, write and sign: *I wrote this paper without outside help.*

What counts — 15 points

Comparative claim	Defines the standard and makes a proportional judgment about both men.	3
Logical autopsy	Reconstructs and diagnoses both private arguments with fitting tools.	4
Textual evidence	Uses accurate, balanced evidence from both supplied passages and the plays.	3
Counterpressure	Treats the strongest complication for each character fairly.	2
Organization	Builds a clear comparison rather than two disconnected summaries.	2
Completion	Is legible, handwritten, and within the assigned length.	1

Minimal Planning Page

U1L17SP — Make the comparison your own

Do not turn this page into the paper. Record only the decisions you need before drafting on separate lined paper.

1. Set a fair standard

In one sentence, define what counts as reasoning dishonestly with oneself. Your standard must be usable for both Macbeth and Brutus.

2. Run two brief autopsies

For **Macbeth**, jot: desire; conclusion or intended action; what he admits; hidden bridge; best exposing tool; fair counterpressure.

For **Brutus**, jot the same six parts. The exposing tool may be different.

3. Build the comparison

What is the most important similarity? What difference matters most to your judgment?

Write the exact quotation from each passage that carries the most weight. Add one broader-play detail for each man, paraphrased accurately if it is not printed in your materials.

4. State and qualify the judgment

Write your present comparative claim. Then name what a fair reader could say against it and revise the claim if needed.

Possible structures, not requirements: point-by-point comparison; one standard tested against both men; apparent winner followed by decisive complication. Choose the structure that keeps the comparison active throughout.

Before submitting: Underline your comparative claim. Mark evidence from Macbeth with M and evidence from Brutus with B. Sign the authorship statement.